

Chapter 19: Something Starts to Break

Jenny started noticing the pattern too late.

Austin didn't ask anymore.

Not for permission.

Not for attention.

Not even for conversation.

He just arrived.

Sat at table seven.

And stayed.

It should have felt easier.

Less intense.

Less demanding.

But somehow...

It felt heavier.

Because now it wasn't curiosity.

It was certainty.

Jenny placed a plate down a little too fast.

Bao leaned in immediately.

"He didn't even order today."

Jenny froze.

"...What?"

"He just sat down."

Jenny looked over.

And there he was.

Austin.

Not even pretending to open a menu.

Just sitting.

Watching the room.

Waiting.

For her.

Jenny exhaled sharply.

"This is ridiculous."

Bao smirked.

"You're smiling."

"I am not smiling."

"You are."

Jenny grabbed a tray.

"Stop talking."

But Bao didn't stop.

"He's getting bolder."

"He's getting annoying."

"He's getting comfortable."

Jenny stopped walking.

That word landed wrong.

Comfortable.

She hated how accurate it felt.

When she approached the table, Austin looked up immediately.

"You're late," he said.

Jenny blinked.

"I didn't even start serving you yet."

"I know."

"...Then what are you talking about?"

"You usually look at me first."

That made her stop.

A beat.

Then Jenny frowned.

"I don't."

"You do."

"I don't."

Austin didn't argue.

He just watched her.

And that was worse.

Jenny crossed her arms.

"You didn't order."

"I didn't need to."

"Why are you here then?"

A pause.

Then—

"I wanted to see if you would come."

Jenny stared at him.

"...That's it?"

"Yes."

"That's not a reason."

"For you."

She shook her head.

"You're acting strange."

"I'm acting honest."

"That's worse."

A faint exhale from him.

Almost a laugh.

But it didn't reach fully.

Jenny placed her hand on the table.

"Order something."

"I'm not hungry."

"Then leave."

"I will."

"When?"

"When you stop standing here pretending you don't feel this too."

Jenny froze.

That sentence hit too clean.

Too precise.

She straightened.

"I don't know what you think I feel."

Austin leaned forward slightly.

"I think you feel it when I look at you."

Jenny's throat tightened.

"I think you feel it when I stay."

She didn't move.

"I think you feel it when I don't leave like everyone else."

Silence.

The restaurant noise faded again.

Jenny forced her voice steady.

"You're imagining things."

Austin shook his head.

"No."

A pause.

Then softer—

"You're just slower at admitting it."

That should have angered her.

It didn't.

It unsettled her instead.

Jenny stepped back.

"This is going too far."

Austin didn't stop her.

But he said quietly,

"No."

Jenny looked at him sharply.

"This is already far."

That made her pause.

Because he was right.

And she hated that more than anything.

Later, Bao caught up to her in the kitchen.

"You're avoiding him more."

"I'm not avoiding anything."

"You're literally walking faster."

"I have work."

Bao leaned against the counter.

"You know what this is, right?"

Jenny didn't answer.

She didn't want to.

Bao continued anyway.

"He's not just a customer anymore."

Jenny tightened her grip on the tray.

"Stop talking."

But Bao didn't.

"He's not leaving, Jenny."

"I noticed."

"And you're not stopping him."

That made her freeze.

For half a second.

Just half.

Then she walked away.

Because she didn't have an answer for that.

Not one she liked.

By evening, the restaurant slowed again.

Austin stayed.

As usual.

Jenny finally approached him when the last customers left.

"You're still here," she said quietly.

"Yes."

"Why?"

Austin looked at her for a long moment.

Then said,

"Because I said I would be."

Jenny frowned.

"That's not an answer."

"It is now."

She studied him.

Something about him felt different again.

Not softer.

Not harder.

Just... decided.

"You're not going to stop this, are you?" she asked.

Austin shook his head.

"No."

A pause.

Then—

"Unless you tell me to leave and mean it."

Jenny went still.

That word.

Mean it.

Because she had told him before.

But not like this.

Not now.

Not when it already felt too late.

She opened her mouth.

Closed it again.

Nothing came out.

Austin noticed.

Of course he did.

Jenny looked away first.

Of course she did.

When she spoke again, her voice was quieter.

"...You make everything complicated."

Austin stood slowly.

"I think I just make it visible."

Jenny didn't respond.

Because that was the problem.

He was right again.

And now...

There was no pretending it wasn't happening anymore.

Austin walked toward the door.

Paused.

Didn't turn around.

But said softly,

"I'll see you tomorrow."

Then he left.

Jenny stood there long after the door closed.

Because for the first time...

She wasn't sure if tomorrow was something she was waiting for.

Or something she was already inside.